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Charles Tolliver

Charles Tolliver was born in Jacksonville, Florida in 1942. He has made his mark in the jazz world as a trumpet player, composer, and co-founder of Strata-East Records

Charles was interviewed via Zoom on May 6, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased, at 10 AM in the morning (not a jazz musician's time usually) but to have Charles Tolliver as a guest today. Thank you for joining me.

CT: You're welcome.

MR: Before I started recording you said you had a lot of tasks but they were all in music — so I'm curious what projects you're able to pursue during this basic time of most things being shut down?

CT: Well it's been a challenge as you can imagine. Basically for the last year and five months all of us have been experiencing this. It's been going out every few days to get provisions, coming back in the house and dealing with as much music as one can to, you know, stay sane I guess.

MR: Am I correct that your grandmother, we can thank your grandmother for handing you a cornet?

CT: Yes. Grandmama Lela.

MR: Can I ask you why you wanted it? What was it that might have been going on in your household or in your neighborhood or on the radio perhaps that made you want to get your hands on that cornet?

CT: Well by the time I was five years old my mom had a genuine Victrola, you know, just like the ones that are in the museum. And she had the Jazz at the Philharmonic recordings by Norman Granz. You know? Pretty hip for that time. And I'd sit myself down and put that big arm on those thick 78s and listening to all of that is what got me to where I am today and I believe it was probably L'il Jazz (Roy Eldridge), and Charlie Shavers, you know, just the sound of the trumpet you know. And of course Dizzy Gillespie. And I guess I was about six or seven or so, you know, just walking through the sandy streets of Jacksonville. You know at that time there were no pavement, there was no asphalt, even for a metropolis town like Jacksonville, certain areas it was just sand you know. And there was this little pawn shop that I would pass every day going from kindergarten back home. And I saw this cornet hanging in the window you know, enticing someone to come

in and get it. And above it was some sheet music of Dizzy Gillespie you know, and I'm saying oh boy, this is right up my alley.

MR: That's like a message from somewhere.

CT: Yeah. So I said to Grandmama, you know, I sure would like to have that cornet. And you know God bless her, you can imagine, we're talking 1947, '48. I don't know how she saved the pennies but she went and got that thing for me. And the rest is history.

MR: That's really interesting. And you must have seen some pictures to connect what you were hearing on the 78s to what the instrument was, or maybe you asked around, like what is that sound?

CT: Well I was already in the drum & bugle corps at my grade school, switching me from the bugle to the drums you know, so music was always there in one form or another all the time. So I mean I knew of course what the instrument looked like and sounded like of course. It was a matter of my getting my hands on one that I could have 24/7 you know.

MR: Yes. It looks like, from what I've read, you took a bit of a detour when it came time for college that you were pursuing a career in pharmacy?

CT: Yeah well this is a Hollywood story you know. So you know, in my last couple of years of high school, of course I was in the swing band and the marching band and the concert band in high school so I'm with that trumpet all the time. And so I wanted to earn a little money and I asked the neighborhood pharmacist, which I believe probably was the only black-owned apothecary, because that's what it was, it wasn't, they didn't have the words "pharmacy" on their window, it was an apothecary. It was really, I mean if you go into the weeds of pharmacology it's about the apothecary and so I'm sitting, waiting — my job was to deliver the medicine to the neighborhood folks and I'm sitting watching them, the two doctors. Because they weren't called pharmacists, they were doctors you know. The title pharmacist was there but you know they were considered pharmacists, I mean apothecarians. So anyway I'm sitting watching them and they are using this mortar and pestle you know and mixing this medicine. And I'm saying to myself, as I was to surmise a little bit later, that if they didn't mix it right the patient just might die. I mean today, you know, in the modern world although folks are trained in pharmacology and they know what the meds are that go into it, but basically when a prescription comes in they just press a ferris wheel and —

MR: And there it is.

CT: There it is, the bottle is there. At that time the pharmacist, he had to mix most of the medicine. And this just intrigued the hell out of me you know. And I said I want to do that. And it didn't dawn on me that it would be any separation from dealing with that and music, so I mean I was accepted at the famous Howard University College of Pharmacy and off I went. And in my third year, most of my time was there — although I was in my

pharmacy studies and pharmaceuticals and everything, but a lot of my time was spent in the fine arts building you know, in the music, down in the dungeons of one of those practice rooms. And in my third year I just, you know after working really hard on that trumpet I made a calculated decision that yes I could go on and finish but if I didn't get this down you know what I was planning to do on the trumpet, so off I went back home and the rest is history you know.

MR: Did your family members or your friends question that decision? And in your head did you consider that making a career as a musician was going to be challenging and probably less of an income than being a pharmacist?

CT: Not for a nanosecond. Because you know the music was in my head since I was five years old. And once I realized that I could actually produce that on the trumpet too, all I wanted to do was belong, nothing more, nothing less. And I didn't think about the fact that it was very chancy to leave my studies in college and go on this, you know, glorious adventure you know. And I did get lucky though, and it takes luck, a bit of luck in this, to meet the right people or be in the right place at the right time. And that sort of really helped to kick-start me just on full steam ahead, this is my life's work.

MR: Did your composing develop as your trumpet playing developed? Let me re-phrase. Do you remember the first time, the first period that you felt I can compose also. I can offer something that can be a tune.

CT: Yes. You know all of our original greats who created this, the realization is is that they are actually composing as they are soloing and it's inextricably tied together, you know, soloing and composing. So you know, by example, Charlie Parker, all of his compositions are solos set down, scripted later, that became part of the underpinnings compositionally of this art form. Thelonious Monk etcetera. You know I mean Duke Ellington, you name it. And I think somewhere after I came back home from college I actually had started to write before I left college, and just you know my first songs you know I started to script them down. And there was a gentleman who is actually still alive, a wonderful musician that in my high school years he taught me how to set down things on manuscript. And from there my first couple of songs that came into my head I did that. And while at Howard University one day I was in the fine arts building of course, in one of the practice rooms, and I happened to pass by a room in which I was hearing these chords being played by a young lady and I knocked on the door and asked if I could come in and I said, "What is that you're playing?" And she said, "Oh those are called 'minor ninths.'" And I said, "Oh really, can you show me that?" And to this day that's what I work off of. And she said to me, "Oh yes, my husband is John Hicks." So they were teenagers I would imagine, they had to have been when they got married. And she went on to get her degree there at Howard. And of course I was to meet John shortly thereafter

in New York and of course the rest is history with that one with us as well. And it was those chords which, you know, open up compositional vistas for me, and arranging and orchestration and so on.

MR: That's a long process and I think nowadays of, we write, many of us, on Finale and those programs where you can sort of hear the music as you write it. And I contrast that with years ago when we would write like a big band chart and that moment when it finally gets played and you hear it, and hopefully you hear it in all its glory but in some cases you're going, "Oh, I didn't know it was going to sound like that."

CT: Yes I mean you know as you gain more knowledge of arranging, orchestration, you know, compositions, one comes to realize that one of the most important things is the weight of the instrument against another instrument. And if you, you know, after trial and error should be able to realize that, you know, if you give too much weight on a section it's going to come out sounding not like what you thought you heard. You know, see the classical musicians from the 1500s on, including Beethoven and all of the greats, Mozart, Haydn, they were lucky. Because all of the musicians were all housed in a barracks at their command every day, so when they scripted out something they brought it over to the barracks, you know, the music area and those guys, you know, played it and they could hear it instantaneously whether it was right or wrong. You know? Think about it.

MR: I do. I think that's why Ellington kept his band together for so long, right? That is an interesting observation. I had a quote here about both your composing and your playing. It comes from one of those Jazz on CD books. And this particular reviewer made the observation that most of your compositions instead of complex chords, I think he's referring to like bebop, "Charles favors basic motifs, four or five notes in an ostinato," and then he continued, "it's very much harder to play inventively over such a background where other chords offer endless permutations of changes. But Tolliver develops solo material apparently without limit in a highly lyrical mainstream style that recalls Clifford Brown." So I think the gist of that is he's pointing out that harmonically your music was simplified from some of those complex fast changes in the bebop world, but you still managed to find ways to solo over that.

CT: Well you know I wouldn't be where I am today, you know, in this art form, had it not been for Jackie McLean. That's what I'm talking about, that lucky break you know. And my first, my debut recording with him, as you know, Jackie was a dye-in-the-wool, you know, bebopper. But that was, I came in during that generational shift just as you know the freer forms were being used. I mean he was already, he had already done "Destination Out" and a couple of other things which portend that he, you know, he wasn't just sitting doing bebop endlessly. And my debut recording with him I mean you know us kids at the time we ate and slept Jackie McLean and all those guys. So we had it down, the bebop

thing. And he wanted something a little bit different. And so you know like half of that recording is bebop and half of it is what you are talking about. And from that experience I think is where I started to do those sorts of things that this person observed in my work. But I think Andrew Hill is the one who really, once I started playing with Andrew and recording with him, you know, that sort of thing really became also a part of my delivery process.

MR: It just occurred to me that 1964 is a significant year for you, it was also the Civil Rights Bill of 1964, and if you extrapolate on that, was the situation socially and politically at that time, do you feel it affected the change in jazz that you're describing?

CT: Well I think that the development of the jazz art form would have happened the way it did even if the social and political developments didn't happen around that same time. But of course a lot of the artists, they delved into that, you know, with the music, you know, Charles Mingus and others, Max Roach you know. But honestly, although I was paying close attention to what was going on socially and politically, I didn't write or play my music with that in mind. Now it might be hard for folks to believe that didn't have that kind of effect on me. But I sort of had blinders on you know. As I said, initially, once I realized I could do something with this art form, I just wanted to belong. And in order for me to accomplish that I put blinders on basically to everything else you know.

MR: Is it safe to say you were obsessed with it?

CT: I was totally obsessed with it, 'til now.

MR: Well it makes me wonder, I was sort of going to ask this question wherever our interview wraps up, but I'll try it now. Do you feel that you have sacrificed or given anything up for this music?

CT: Absolutely not. If I had it to do all over again I'd do exactly the same. Every bit of it you know. I mean we are blessed in a way, you know, us artisans I mean and it doesn't matter which idiom it is: jazz music, classical music, popular music, minimalist, you know. Because Art Blakey's well-said powerful in that inimitable voice of his, you know, when he would get off the drums and speak to the audience and said, "We're here to wash away the dust of your everyday life." And so I carry that in mind you know. And so —

MR: When you recorded, performed and composed, did you have something in mind that you hoped your audience would glean from your work?

CT: Yes because as soloing and composition is inextricably tied to the musician, so is his communication to the audience. Without the audience, which is why this pandemic so much affected everything, where you don't have a live audience to feed off of your offering. And for me it's like you know the heavyweight fight that's coming up where you're in the dressing room and you're getting taped up and get ready to go out and give the best performance you can, the audience, you can feel when you hit the stage certainly

if they know your work and they're there, and you can also feel and see those who are there to see what this is all about and if they like it or not. And just from that, just a glance, it's just sort of a finger in the wind and off you go with the music. And it's so vitally important, the interaction with the musicians on stage and the audience.

MR: If you felt that you weren't reaching the bulk of the audience, were there things that you worked on adjusting?

CT: No. Because my thing is to assemble the very best at this, you know — whatever the event is, the venue — musicians. And this is from as a child and as a teenager watching because I got a chance to see just about everybody you know, just about everybody who was still alive when I broke in. And to the man, they never peopled their bands with anything less than just super musicians. And so that stuck with me and so when I come onstage with a unit it's absolutely crack. And so between starting and ending you know, that performance or that concert I think the audience is, I've never felt that they didn't get it or that they didn't appreciate what we offered. I mean you know of course there's a famous true, historical story that when "The Rite of Spring" was performed in Paris you know what happened. And it was a mistake by that audience you know. But it didn't stop Stravinsky, not one second. And I mean today it's just one of the greatest works of all time. It will last forever. And now when audiences go they go there, you know, specifically to hear it and to enjoy it, now that they realize historically how important a work it is you know. But with soloing performances, you know classical music is the composer's performance. You know the orchestra, if it's a well trained orchestra, they can play a great work without the conductor. Absolutely. A great orchestra led by a great concertmaster, well rehearsed, they do not need the conductor. So you know — there you are.

MR: Okay. I wonder if you have ever attended a concert, let's say someone like Albert Ayler who was on the far end of where things could go, and witnessed a reaction like the audience at the premier of "The Rite of Spring"?

CT: Well you know those fellows, when they were creating that free form thing, and I watched that because I broke in right at the same time, there wasn't an audience really. There was like a few family and friends. And you know the writers in the magazines gave it a big lift you know. And then people started to say well what is this all about, and started to come. And there were two places on the Lower East Side where this was incubated and really got going. And one was called a speakeasy. Actually that place is still there, I mean the location of it, where these guys would go and work on this. And there was a place called Slug's, a little bit farther east on the Lower East Side of Manhattan, in what we call Alphabet City, you know, Avenue A, B, C, and D. And there it started to really get legs you know in those places. And the rest is history with that too I

mean for the beboppers, so-called straight ahead guys, you know some of it got incorporated into, you know, the mainstream of things. And just like with classical music you know, things got worked out. I mean a perfect example is I mean I guess my all-time favorite classical composer, musician, is Bartok. And the reason why is not only is his works, you know, just out of this world great, but you know he said you know I'm really a Bach guy. You know? But he took that and did like what happened with all our form, with the guys that started there, it got synthesized and worked up into the main body, the quintessential body of the art form. Because Bartok's earlier work, you can hear that he loved Bach you know? But then when you hear the string quartet it's unsurpassed. And so you know, then you hear like, who you mentioned, Albert Ayler and Archie Schepp. I mean Archie Schepp actually is not as far out as was Albert Ayler and some of the other guys. Because Archie can go either way, as you know, until today. And all of the, you know my generation that was coming up then it didn't matter what the instrument, they all synthesized some of that and made it even better, what was being attempted. So that's my take on it.

MR: I wondered on occasion if the musicians like yourself and the fellas you mentioned sat around and talked about how they were going to play. Was there discussions that said like we might say, all right, we're not going to play in this particular time signature, we're just going to see what happens? Or I guess what I'm trying to say was any of this music pre-planned before you got on the bandstand or did it happen as it was being created?

CT: I would imagine some of it did happen as it was being created, that whoever was the band leader said, you know, this is, you know, these couple of notes or whatever, maybe. Let's just work off of that and, you know, see what we get. You know John Coltrane, I mean we all got a chance to watch that develop you know, from the beginning when he put that quartet together, finally, who were going to be in it for that run 'til his death. And they rehearsed you know. And when it got to the point when he decided he wanted to go interstellar I think he probably gave a couple of notes you know, to work off of, to McCoy and off they went. I mean in that case, where you have a band where each instrumentalist in the band is creating a path that's going to be historical, then young players pick up on that and if they want to do that they probably say I want this to go something like on that record or on this record you know. But I worked with Andrew Hill, Andrew scripted out a lead sheet. But he never said okay you have to play it this way or that way. It was really just a guidepost. Because he expected you to take it and do how you wanted to do with it.

MR: Would a musician like —

CT: That was a, you know, my experience with Andrew Hill was very important in my career because of how he handled what you're asking about.

MR: Would a musician like Andrew or others who were quote sort of leading, would they ever fire a musician or would they just sort of move on if they weren't happy with what was being offered?

CT: Well of course some musicians got verbally fired I would imagine. But generally you just never got called again.

MR: Have you ever had to do that?

CT: No.

MR: I'm glad to hear that.

CT: Well what do you mean? Have I ever had to fire a musician? I've had to not use a musician because I just felt that they needed to do what they were doing somewhere else.

MR: Good way to put it. Yeah.

CT: Yeah. And you know as I said I don't people the band unless the musician is great on his instrument. So it had nothing to do with the fact that they weren't great on their instrument. It had to do with what they were doing with that you know.

MR: Let's talk about Strata-East. I'm going to read another quote about the label. This was a description: "Strata-East operated on a minimal finance and maximal passion, a pivotal platform for the independent jazz movement that emerged from the Civil Rights in the 1970s." And before that they had mentioned Pharaoh Sanders as being on the label with one album I guess, and they called him one of the leaders of the movement. So my question is did you and Stanley Cowell feel that your label was part of some movement?

CT: Well there are three things in what you just read which need to be clarified. Let's put it that way. The label that it was to become wasn't created because, again, of the political or social environment going on. So you know what you said about, can you read that again so I can —

MR: Yeah. He —

CT: Yeah, just read what you read.

MR: Okay. "Operated on a minimal finances, maximal passion, a pivotal platform for the independent jazz movement that emerged from Civil Rights in the 1970s.

CT: Okay. Okay. It didn't emerge from the Civil Rights Movement because my idea to do an independent endeavor like this stemmed from let's say two events. First of all, when I was coming up and you really got into this, you either got your own leader date at Blue Note or one of the other independents that was going on at the time. That didn't happen to me nor did it happen for Woody Shaw, because both of us were coming up at the same time. It should have, you know, because of who we recorded with on Blue Note. Both of us recorded with Jackie McLean and Horace Silver, and both worked in the Horace Silver band and Max Roach as well. But Alfred Lion sold Blue Note records in 1966, right? Or '65. And he didn't get around to giving us a record date. Things would be

completely different in terms of the historical thing of my career had that happened. So by 1968, '69, I was already, I already had this what was going to become Strata-East records. I was going to do it, it was just a matter of time. And because my dear Stanley Cowell and I were so close you know, every day, and working with Max Roach and watching what he did it was inevitable at that particular time, in 1970, that we were going to go in the studio and make a recording which would be the first record to launch the label and it had nothing to do with anything else but us finally putting out a product under our own name and see where it goes you know? In fact I shopped it first to the independents but it was a big band record so they weren't biting on it and I didn't care because I was going to do it anyway. So it had absolutely nothing to do with that first part of what you just read, and I appreciate that they could read into that that it did because it happened right when the country was steaming. And LBJ, as he was told by his famous Senate colleague, you know if you do this you'll lose the South. And that's exactly what happened, politically. But I wasn't, that didn't factor in you know, or the unrest and of course the riots that happened, you know, with Martin Luther King's death and everything. Everything was already incubated to do what we were going to do with Strata-East before any of that happened. Now I don't know if, Pharoah Sanders was a part of the free jazz movement, but he was going to be who he became anyway. Let's put it this way, I think they were all obviously they've said this, without John Coltrane that would not have happened. And so the reason why Pharaoh Sanders' recording landed with Strata-East was because of the great Clifford Jordan. I mean actually the — when Clifford Jordan saw what we did with the first recording he said to me, he said, "You know I've already done that." And he had. He had already recorded Pharaoh Sanders and four others, which he called the Dolphy Series. And he said, "Hey, here you go, run with it." So Clifford Jordan was as important as anything that ever we came with in Strata-East because it helped to further jumpstart this venture. And of course Pharoah Sanders' record was one of them and so it became, you know, one of the signature issues, you know, of the label. But — and I'll just go on with this since we're on this Strata-East topic, now after about two years in all the musicians' ears started to prop up, you know, what's going on with this Strata-East thing you know. And you know one day, you know, a guy walked into the office named Gil Scott Heron and he said, "I want to do that too." He had, like everybody else, was required to already have done their product. We created a conduit by which it would get to the marketplace. And of course the rest is history with that one because it just so happened that he had one track on there that took off.

MR: Can I pause for a moment there. Are you saying that the artists had their recordings already completed and they came to you for whatever your label could offer?

CT: Exactly. And see there was the misunderstanding, the rest of the industry had other musicians and everything during that time, up until today for a lot of them, because they never understood how it worked and the reason why is because I wanted it that way. I wanted it to have the look of a regular record company. And the assumption was that we were putting these artists under contract and issuing their product. I would never have had that kind of a venture. It was about the musician investing in himself. And becoming the major recipient of what came back. That's how I function. So when this fellow who wrote this saying "on a minimal budget" it was less than a minimal budget. I mean if I think back I don't know how I was able to negotiate the business in terms of having an office finally, to do all this. But I mean I was able to do that, I mean you know — if I was going to be a pharmacist, that meant that I was pretty good at chess, I was pretty good at chemistry and math. So you know you don't have to only just be a musician. I think most musicians are pretty good at chess and those things too. It just so happened that I could multi-task at the drop of a hat so that's the way it went. So yes, each musician, they would come and say, "Wow, I'd like to do that. How do you do that?" I said, "Well do you have a product all ready?" "Well not yet." I'd say, "Go get one, go make one." Or if they already knew that that was the deal they would come with it all ready, we'd listen to it and we'd say okay boom, you're in, go.

MR: Did you ever have someone come in with their product and say, "Well this has potential?" Did you get in a position where you started giving advice, try again, and make it more this or that?

CT: No. So when they'd come it was wow man, okay, here's a young fellow, he wants to do this, I'd listen to it and if it was decently recorded and the package was nice I might suggest you might want to do this with the cover or something. But all of them already saw the covers of things that had already come out so you know, there wasn't an art department that created these things, they did.

MR: I see.

CT: That's the beauty of it you know. And so the rest is history. And I mean at one point I think we had about 65 all told. And the deal was that if you're unsatisfied, you know, with the result you know, you can take your product and start to do it yourself you know? Which did happen you know, with some of them. And that was fine. The whole idea was that it would be influential to enough musicians who were known and were working that the product would sell itself, because they're working and avid to sell you know on their venues or whatever, besides the mom & pop distribution system you know that we had set up you know during those years. And this all went for about ten years you know. And around 1980 I decided to slow things down because I just needed to take a break. I had gone hard at that for ten years you know. The operation never ceased, it never stopped. I

just went quiet with it you know. And anyway the digital age was coming and I just, you know during the 80s I just concentrated solely on writing music, taking bands wherever. And around '89 with the digital format now getting ready to really shoot out there, I re-tooled and re-issued on CD just those LPs that I liked that we still were doing. The LP merchandising never stopped because the Japanese, you know, they were gung ho on this from the jump. And the Brits, you know. So overseas things still went on as usual. I just wasn't going to be strapped down to going into an office situation you know.

MR: Did you ever feel the need to take a break not only from your label but from actually performing and composing? Did the business of finding gigs, etcetera — I can see you're shaking your head so that, yeah —

CT: No. That would have been impossible, not only because of how I am but because I am my grandmother and my mother. So you finish what you start. So it was never, that was not going to happen. So it was never a thought of doing that, it's always been full out, full stop. 'Til now. I think maybe that's what keeps me going you know, is I still, as I began, I just wanted to belong you know? I just wanted to belong to this great art form, and so I was given a chance to do that by Jackie McLean.

MR: I wonder if we return to that 1964 date with Jackie if you can describe or you have a specific memory of that first recording and being in the studio or wherever it was and thinking, I'm trying to phrase this — did you have a feeling like yeah, now I'm getting there. Now I'm jumping in? This is a significant moment for me?

CT: I'll say this, at one point my knees were shaking you know. You know when I decided to leave Howard University with my pharmacy studies and grapple with this thing, that was the moment where I said I know I can do this. And so anything that came after that was like gravy for me because I, you know, I knew I could play that trumpet now the way I was hearing it. And so what stood out for me was that Jackie McLean, so I was sent to Jackie McLean, who actually is the guy responsible for me being where I am in terms of being in this now, Jim Harrison, God bless him he's still alive. So he, he had a Jackie McLean fan club. And in 1963 when I came back home why he was going around and you're doing all the jam sessions of course, and this famous place in Brooklyn called the Blue Coronet, he was there listening, happened to be there that night and you know I'm jamming on the bandstand with some new arrivals to New York nobody had heard of before either, you know Jack DeJohnette. And we're all brand new to this stuff you know, the scene. And so he come up to the bandstand and Jim Harrison said, "Okay, by the way, you know Jackie McLean is, he might be looking for a trumpet player." And he sent me to Jackie and that's how I met Jackie. I told him that Jim Harrison sent me. And Jackie said, "Okay, come see me at this time" and see what's going on. So I went to Jackie's house and he says, "I've got these tunes. Let's go over them." He played them.

And he says, “Do you have any tunes?” I said, “Yes I do.” He says, “Let me hear them, let me play them.” He says, “Okay I’m putting you on my next record date.” Now I’ve told that story many times and every time people said you’ve got to be kidding. He hadn’t heard you yet. I said, “Well he was going on what Jim Harrison said, ‘Hey you know there’s a new trumpet player in town.’” You know. Boom. And so, and then to get on that, there was a place called Len Oliver’s Studio, it was a famous place on 89th and Broadway where most rehearsals went down. And that’s what Alfred Lion used for rehearsing bands before taking them to Rudy Van Gelder’s. And I arrived for the first day’s rehearsal, I did not know who Jackie McLean was having on his record date. I just knew wow, I’m going to be on my first record date. And I get to the studio and Alfred and Frank Wolff, his beloved partner is there. And I looked at the drums and there’s Roy Haynes sitting on the drums so I’m already, oh man. And then you know, in walks Herbie Hancock you know, on the piano. The only new person, new persons, was me and Cecil McBee. That’s his first time out. And Alfred starts his stopwatch, we go through the tunes, and there’s this famous hotel, it’s still there, the Empire Hotel was the meeting place. That’s where every one of those great recordings of Blue Note started. The old Checker Cab would be waiting in front of the hotel with a box full of sandwiches and beer, soda, liquor. We all pile in those Checker Cabs and off to Rudy Van Gelder’s across the George Washington Bridge we’d go. And that first recording, I still think that’s one of the best recordings of Jackie and all of us on there. Because it was, as we started this conversation, it was loose and free but at the same time cohesive with the modern bebop jazz element as well. And the interplay between Roy Haynes and Herbie Hancock is just absolutely miraculous. I mean it’s one of the greatest performances by those two together ever, and the only time they’ve ever been commercially recorded you know, for a label. So that particular record, not only being my debut record, it’s a substantial contribution.

MR: That’s a terrific story. I’m going to make a proposal here. We’ve been talking for an hour and I wonder if I could engage you for a part 2 in the near future?

CT: Sure.

MR: All right. Because there’s lots of things I haven’t got to and some things I want to follow up. I mean just like you just said Alfred “started the stopwatch.” Well I want to know about that. So we’ll return to some of those things. So I’ll pause our recording and we’ll say goodbye for today and we’ll meet down the road.

CT: Sounds good.